Idioms in New Scientist

17 October 2026 issue · every idiom with its exact sentence from the magazine, in page order. All 52 PDF pages were checked; pages with no article text are full-page adverts or photo/illustration pages.

The leader & El Niño special report (pages 3–11)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
1	**wreak havoc** cause great damage or chaos	THE world faces a difficult period ahead, as the El Niño weather phenomenon looks set to **wreak havoc**.	4
2	**off the charts** extremely high; beyond normal measurement	MIND-BLOWING. Unprecedented. **Off the charts.** Godzilla-level.	4
3	**on track to** likely to reach a result	Hundreds of thousands of people have faced respiratory illness, and carbon emissions are **on track to** equal Indonesia's catastrophic 2015 fires.	4
4	**coming down the pike** about to happen; on its way	"It gives us a glimpse of what is **coming down the pike** if we continue to warm the planet with carbon pollution."	5
5	**on the brink of** very close to (a disaster)	Northern and eastern Ethiopia have seen crop failures and South Sudan is **on the brink of** famine after one of the driest June-September rainy seasons on record, a fall linked to El Niño.	5
6	**all but (fell apart)** almost completely	Society **all but fell apart**.	6
7	**far from clear** not at all clear	Scientists knew something strange was happening to global weather patterns, but the cause was **far from clear**.	6
8	**the "big bang" (for)** the starting point that launched something	That was the **"big bang"** for El Niño research, says Michael McPhaden at the US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration.	6
9	**forewarned is forearmed** knowing in advance lets you prepare	"**Being forewarned is being forearmed.** If you know something is coming and it can have really damaging impacts, you have some choices to make," says McPhaden.	7
10	**a head start** an advantage gained by starting early	That gave governments a three-month **head start** before the El Niño even began, and at least six months of warning before impacts would be felt.	7
11	**bear the scars (of)** show the lasting damage of	EACH purple carrot the farmers pull from the clumpy soil of West Sussex **bears the scars** of extreme weather.	8
12	**an omen of** a sign of something (usually bad) to come	Rain pours down as Chadwick and Farber work, **an omen of** the warm, wet, stormy weather that El Niño is expected to bring to the UK this autumn and winter.	8
13	**a tale of two …** a story of two very different outcomes	The result will be **a tale of two** socioeconomic statuses.	8
14	**pay top dollar** pay a very high price	"The UK may be willing to **pay top dollar**," says Christian Jaccarini at the Energy and Climate Intelligence Unit, a UK non-profit.	8
15	**push back against** resist or oppose	At the same time, she **pushed back against** "panic and fear" after environment minister Angela Eagle told Britons they should "store a bit of food".	9
16	**on the back of** following; as a result of	"We will have a wetter start to this winter… **On the back of** a very dry summer, that is difficult," said White.	9

The leader & El Niño special report (pages 3–11)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
17	**wipe (someone) out** ruin someone completely	“The summer really **wiped us out**.”	9
18	**brace for** prepare yourself for something difficult	AS COUNTRIES around the world **brace for** a torrid few months as El Niño hits, what if we could take the sting out of its tail?	10
19	**take the sting out of (its tail)** reduce the painful effect of something	…what if we could **take the sting out of its tail** – or even stop it from happening altogether?	10
20	**a big but** a serious objection or condition	But – and it is **a big but** – the technical feasibility of deploying artificial upwelling on this scale would be a “major, major undertaking”, she says.	10
21	**on the front line** where the action or danger is greatest	Inside the oceans, coral reefs are **on the front line** of the El Niño crisis.	11
22	**come to fruition** succeed; become real	After extensive trials, that idea never **came to fruition** – but Qiao realised the work could be repurposed for coral reefs.	11
23	**in its infancy** at a very early stage of development	Just like with many of the protection efforts against El Niño, coral shading is still **in its infancy**.	11
24	**here to stay** permanent; not going away	…but, for now, El Niño is **here to stay**.	11
25	**end with a bang** finish suddenly and dramatically	The 1997 El Niño **ended with a bang**, with sea-surface temperatures in the eastern equatorial Pacific plummeting by 8°C in a month.	11

AI & mathematics news (pages 12–13)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
26	**the floodgates have opened** a sudden, uncontrollable flow has started	THE **floodgates** of AI mathematics **have opened**.	12
27	**let’s face it** we must accept the truth	“**Let’s face it**, the genie is out of the bottle now. We’re going to have to live with it.”	12
28	**the genie is out of the bottle** something has happened that cannot be undone	“Let’s face it, **the genie is out of the bottle** now. We’re going to have to live with it.”	12
29	**stand back** watch without getting involved	“I think for the moment, we just **stand back** and be astonished,” says Johnson.	12
30	**comb through** search very carefully	Of course, there hasn’t yet been time for mathematicians to **comb through** all of these results, **let alone** to actually check them.	12
31	**let alone** and certainly not	…there hasn’t yet been time for mathematicians to comb through all of these results, **let alone** to actually check them.	12
32	**go to press** be sent for printing	As New Scientist **went to press**, three had already been retracted.	12

AI & mathematics news (pages 12–13)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
33	**make a splash** attract a lot of attention	Nevertheless, even a preliminary comb through the thicket of papers turns up some that are likely to **make a splash**.	12
34	**take aim at** target; try to tackle	Now, OpenAI has **taken aim at** the Riemann hypothesis, an unproven rule about the distribution of prime numbers.	12
35	**take (something) on board** accept and act on advice	OpenAI has previously said that it would **take this advice on board**, but its most recent release seems to go against many of the group's suggestions.	13
36	**the bottom line** the most important point	**The bottom line** is that with such a huge body of research all dropping at once, it could take years for mathematicians to check.	13
37	**a real boon** a great benefit	If AI maths continues at this pace, it could be **a real boon** or a real problem for the field of mathematics as a whole.	13

Health, nature & space news (pages 14–16)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
38	**down the line** at some point in the future	This is defined as plaque that isn't causing any symptoms, but may lead to cardiovascular issues **down the line**.	14
39	**telltale** revealing; giving something away	Magdalena and his team examined satellite photos and found **telltale** green dots confirming there really were giant waterlilies growing there.	14
40	**the tip of the iceberg** a small visible part of a much bigger thing	"…so it's just **the tip of the iceberg** in terms of a whole and mostly hidden technology that ran in parallel with the much better-known stone tools of the Palaeolithic."	15
41	**fill in the gaps** supply the missing parts	Instead, they had to assemble fragments from Jonathan's saliva … and **fill in the gaps** using DNA from another Aldabra tortoise.	16

Hannah Fry column – Maths' existential crisis (page 19)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
42	**pull (someone) to one side** take someone aside to speak privately	…a professor of algebraic number theory **pulled me to one side** and gave me some sharp words of warning.	19
43	**a bit of a snob** someone who looks down on others	He was being **a bit of a snob**.	19
44	**titting around** (British slang) messing about, wasting time	Maths had an intimidating mystique to maintain, and I was apparently jeopardising it by **titting around** on the internet making videos and podcasts.	19
45	**come around to the idea** gradually change your opinion and accept	But buried beneath his snobbery, I have **come around to the idea** that he was right about something.	19
46	**throw everything at it** use every possible resource	…it **threw everything at it**: 10,000 AI agents, costing millions of dollars in tokens, to find a single example where everything blows up.	19
47	**a big deal** something very important	This particular gem was such **a big deal** to the mathematical community that … the Clay Mathematics Institute promised it would give $1 million to whoever managed to solve it.	19

Hannah Fry column – Maths' existential crisis (page 19)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
48	**have a wobble** (British) a moment of doubt or loss of confidence	…mathematicians have spent the past few weeks **having a massive collective wobble**.	19
49	**slap down on the table** put forward carelessly or forcefully	…hundreds of thousands of lines of formal code **slapped down on the table** and left for the mathematicians to **pick apart**.	19
50	**pick apart** examine closely to find faults	…left for the mathematicians to **pick apart**, while the AI labs move on to the next thing.	19
51	**to top it off** on top of everything else (often bad)	Now, **to top it off**, the new tranche of proofs that landed last week claim to have **polished off** hundreds of other important, unsolved mathematical problems.	19
52	**polish off** finish something quickly and completely	…claim to have **polished off** hundreds of other important, unsolved mathematical problems.	19
53	**don't get me wrong** don't misunderstand me	Please **don't get me wrong**.	19
54	**at its best / at its worst** in its best or worst form	I know that, **at its best**, AI has a great deal to offer. But **at its worst**, AI is an engine of extraction.	19
55	**the sting in the tail** an unpleasant surprise at the end	**The real sting in the tail** is that OpenAI set its sights on mathematics because the prestige, the respect and the glory were just another thing that could be mined.	19
56	**set one's sights on** aim to achieve or get	…OpenAI **set its sights on** mathematics because the prestige, the respect and the glory were just another thing that could be mined.	19

Sweet tooth – Alice Klein (page 20)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
57	**a sweet tooth** a love of sugary food	**Sweet tooth** – Supermarket aisles are jam-packed full of baby and toddler foods high in sugar.	20
58	**jam-packed** completely full	Supermarket aisles are **jam-packed** full of baby and toddler foods high in sugar.	20
59	**tuck into** start eating eagerly (here: examine eagerly)	Alice Klein **tucks into** the evidence for cutting out sugar from infants' diets up until the age of 2.	20
60	**like trying to run through rain without getting wet** attempting something impossible	I realised that trying to shield them from sugar was **like trying to run through rain without getting wet**, and I suspected I needed to chill out anyway.	20
61	**chill out** relax; calm down	…and I suspected I needed to **chill out** anyway.	20
62	**pique (one's) interest** arouse curiosity	**My interest was thus piqued** by a recent study that used a neat natural experiment.	20
63	**set for life** fixed permanently	…sugar exposure in utero and during infancy shapes ageing processes in our cells, which are then **set for life**.	20
64	**downright** completely; thoroughly	I don't think we need to implement a full sugar ban … since this would be impractical and **downright mean**.	20

Sweet tooth – Alice Klein (page 20)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
65	**uptight** anxious and overly strict	I didn’t want to overload her guests with sugar, but I also didn’t want to be an **uptight** parent denying them simple joys.	20

Culture & books (pages 22–28)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
66	**get hands-on (with)** take part directly; touch and try	On the show floor, people could journey through a giant inflatable gut, 3D-print organs and **get hands-on** with large insects.	22
67	**have a go** try something	Holdout Daniel Cossins is now persuaded to **have a go**.	26
68	**precious little** very little	MAYBE I should be embarrassed to admit this, but I have made **precious little** effort to engage with artificial intelligence.	26
69	**whether we like it or not** regardless of our wishes	AI is here, **whether we like it or not**.	26
70	**cover a lot of ground** deal with many topics	In providing answers, Mollick **covers a lot of ground**.	26
71	**the likes of** people or things such as	…examples of his gratifyingly meta conversations with **the likes of** Claude, Gemini and ChatGPT.	26
72	**rattle through** go through quickly	One minor criticism is that the book **rattles through** some of the more unsettling aspects.	26
73	**bring to the table** contribute something useful	The book is also reassuring about what humans still **bring to the table**, not least our powers of judgement, taste and, most importantly, agency.	27
74	**slog away** work hard for a long time	But for me, and all the other holdouts inefficiently **slogging away** without using AI to its full potential…	27
75	**not lost on (me)** noticed and understood by me	Indeed, it **wasn’t lost on me** that I began the book wondering if engaging with AI would mean giving something up.	27
76	**hold out** resist; refuse to give in	…but now I am thinking I might be losing something by **holding out**.	27
77	**roar through (a book)** read very quickly with enthusiasm	But I did **roar through it** – Niffenegger is such an elegant and compelling storyteller.	27
78	**second thoughts** reconsidering an earlier opinion	**Second thoughts** – The award-winning When There Are Wolves Again by E. J. Swift somehow delivers both a determined call for more wildernesses globally – and a great novel.	28
79	**for want of a better word** because there is no better word	I thought it was going to be, **for want of better words**, “do-goody” and a bit dull.	28
80	**give it a go** try it	…I have returned to it, determined to **give it more of a go**.	28
81	**stand by** continue to support (an opinion)	Firstly, I **stand by** my assessment of the first chapter.	28

Culture & books (pages 22–28)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
82	**talk about …!** used to emphasise something extreme	…with the half-dog tucked into her clothes. **Talk about tense!**	28
83	**pull off** succeed in something difficult	It realistically imagines our very near future, which is a bold thing to try and a very hard thing to **pull off**.	28
84	**tie oneself in knots** become very confused or anxious	As a writer, you have to somehow avoid getting **wrapped up in knots** about what might happen in real life.	28
85	**Boy, does … !** expression of strong emphasis	**Boy, does Swift deliver.**	28
86	**burst into tears** suddenly start crying	Very unusually for me, I **burst into tears** over the final lines.	28
87	**you heard it here first (twisted)** playful twist: “you heard it here last”	What an achievement this is. **You heard it here last!**	28

Letters & AI consciousness feature (pages 31–35)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
88	**open a can of worms** create a complicated set of new problems	Simulated reality question **opens a can of worms**.	31
89	**Goldilocks (conditions)** exactly right – not too much, not too little	Life may need **Goldilocks conditions**: habitable temperatures, billions of years of liquid water and a suitable radiation flux.	31
90	**one can only hope** we wish, but can’t be sure	If this happened, then politicians might take notice. **One can only hope!**	31
91	**stick with what we know** stay with the familiar	**Better to stick with what we know.**	31
92	**(someone’s) ears are burning** they are being talked about	“Claude’s **ears will be burning** by the end of the week,” a fellow passenger tells me.	32
93	**thrash out** discuss thoroughly to reach a solution	…they will **thrash out** the problem of which entities – babies, octopuses and even chatbots – have an inner life.	32
94	**the biggest names** the most famous people	Some of **the biggest names** in philosophy and neuroscience have gathered on a commercial yacht.	32
95	**loaded terms** words carrying hidden assumptions	Covert thinking and self-monitoring are **loaded terms** in the context of a chatbot.	35
96	**you’d better not use feathers** saying: don’t copy nature exactly to build a machine	“If you want to build a plane, **you’d better not use feathers**.”	35

Cancer in the crosshairs (pages 37–39)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
97	**in the crosshairs** targeted; under attack	**Cancer in the crosshairs**	37
98	**what makes (it) tick** what makes it work or behave as it does	“Being able to identify exactly **what makes a cancer tick** is having an incredible impact,” says David Thomas.	37
99	**put on a brave front** pretend not to be afraid	“I **put on a brave front**, but **deep down** I was terrified.”	37
100	**deep down** in one’s true feelings	“I put on a brave front, but **deep down** I was terrified. I didn’t know if I’d be here in six months.”	37
101	**hit the lottery** have very good luck	Through this fresh approach, Huff **“hit the lottery”** – as his oncologist told him.	37
102	**a death sentence** something certain to cause death	…more and more people like Huff are surviving cancers that were once considered **a death sentence**, like lung, pancreatic and brain cancer.	37
103	**little fanfare** little public attention	But surprisingly, it has received **little fanfare** outside of the medical community so far.	37
104	**stumble upon** discover by chance	The common chemotherapy drug cisplatin, for example, was **stumbled upon** by scientists playing around with platinum electrodes and bacteria in the 1960s.	37
105	**trial and error** trying many ways until one works	Over time, blind **trial and error** worked out which of these drugs worked best for each cancer type.	37
106	**go awry** go wrong	The new era of precision oncology is instead informed by the exact gene that has **gone awry** in a person’s cancer.	37
107	**pave the way for** make something possible later	These discoveries **paved the way for** some of the first targeted drugs, including one called imatinib.	37
108	**shoot up** increase quickly	…the survival rate for chronic myeloid leukaemia eight years after diagnosis has **shot up** to almost 90 per cent.	37
109	**pick up momentum** gain speed and strength	The field **picked up momentum** in the 2010s.	37
110	**the worst of the worst** the very worst	This is even the case for pancreatic cancer, known as the **“worst of the worst”** cancer.	38
111	**make inroads** start to make progress	Another of the most feared malignancies is brain cancer, but precision oncology is starting to **make inroads** here, too.	38
112	**as the evidence stacks up** as more proof builds up	**As the evidence stacks up**, countries like Japan, Germany, Norway and Denmark have recently made comprehensive genomic profiling routinely available.	38
113	**pay out of pocket** pay with your own money	…meaning they can access it only if they **pay for it out of pocket**.	39
114	**a headache** a problem or difficulty	Another **headache** for precision oncology is the issue of drug resistance.	39
115	**build up an arsenal** collect many weapons/resources	That means we have to keep **building up our arsenal** of targeted drugs.	39

Cancer in the crosshairs (pages 37–39)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
116	**one of the brightest lights** one of the best or most promising	**One of the brightest lights** in the world of precision oncology is a programme called Zero Childhood Cancer.	39
117	**doing his thing** doing what he enjoys or is good at	"…because he's up there **doing his thing**, he is full of joy."	39
118	**a thing of the past** something that no longer exists	…children dying from cancer will eventually become **a thing of the past**.	39
119	**not a matter of if, but when** it will certainly happen	"It's **not a matter of if, but when**," he says.	39
120	**a poster child** a perfect example of something	"I'm **a poster child** of what modern medicine can achieve."	39

Roman Space Telescope interview (pages 40–43)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
121	**a giant leap** a huge advance	It doesn't sound like a lot, but that is **a giant leap** from its predecessors.	40
122	**pièce de résistance** the best or most impressive part	But the **pièce de résistance** will be what it can do for our studies of dark matter and dark energy.	40
123	**first things first** deal with the most important thing first	So, **first things first**: how was it to finally see that first image?	41
124	**around the clock** all day and all night	The teams are on duty 24/7, so there are a lot of people on shifts **around the clock**.	41
125	**on a high** very happy and excited	Leading up to this, we're all kind of **on a high**.	41
126	**in good shape** in a good condition	…it's telling us that we're **in really good shape**.	41
127	**no offence taken** I'm not upset by what you said	**No offense taken** at all!	41
128	**the only game in town** the only available option	Roman isn't **the only game in town**. But it's the newest game in town.	43

Back pages (pages 46–48)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
129	**crocodile tears** fake tears; insincere sadness	Someone able to cry convincingly without experiencing the corresponding emotion may manipulate the response of others, known as **crocodile tears**.	46
130	**on demand** whenever wanted	Actors complicate matters further because some can deliberately summon a genuine emotional response and cry **on demand**.	46

Back pages (pages 46–48)

#	Idiom / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
131	**jog on** (British slang) go away – used here as a pun	**Jog on** – Is it faster to jog up the stairs or take them two at a time?	46
132	**don’t hold your breath** don’t expect it to happen soon	A movie is currently in development, but … it seems best not to **hold one’s breath**.	48
133	**a matter of debate** something people disagree about	So, it’s **a matter of debate** whether the cookpot went to space or just really high.	48
134	**get beaned** (slang) be hit on the head	“Imagine getting **beaned** by a Le Creuset Dutch oven dropped from 110,000 feet.”	48
135	**keen on** enthusiastic about	Feedback is always **keen on** a new scientific acronym.	48
136	**to boldly go (pun)** twist on Star Trek’s “to boldly go”	**To boldly cook**	48